

The Man Who Walked on the Moon



INTRODUCTION

BRIEF BIOGRAPHY OF J. G. BALLARD

J. G. Ballard was born to British parents in Shanghai, China. At a young age, Ballard experienced the effects of the Second Sino-Japanese War, which changed his worldview and eventually helped inspire one of his most famous works, *Empire of the Sun*. In 1945, Ballard moved to England to study medicine, but he ended up dropping out of college to work as a writer. After publishing one of his early short stories, he struggled to place his work, and in 1954 he joined the Royal Air Force, where he served for about a year before leaving. In 1955 he met and married Helen Mary Matthews, and in 1956 they had their first of three children. By the end of the same year, Ballard published his next two stories and decided to pursue writing professionally. Ballard became a pioneer of New Wave Science Fiction, and his first novels, *The Wind From Nowhere* and *The Drowned World* explored society's responses to natural disaster. *Crash*, published in 1973, became controversially famous for its characters' obsession with violence and psychosexuality. Ballard's most successful novel was *Empire of the Sun*, which was eventually adapted into a movie directed by Steven Spielberg.

HISTORICAL CONTEXT

J. G. Ballard was one of the prominent writers of New Wave Science Fiction, a response to the strict cultural separation between literature and genre fiction like fantasy and sci-fi. New Wave turned the questions of science fiction inward, and instead of looking at the possibilities for science in the physical world, it looked at the science of the self: psychology and sociology were major topics for New Wave writers. This is most obvious in "The Man Who Walked on the Moon" when the narrator's curiosities fall not on the technological excitement of the Apollo missions, but on the ways they (allegedly) affected Scranton. The Apollo Program consisted of 14 space flight missions run by NASA between the years of 1961 and 1972. The most famous of these missions was Apollo 11, which landed the first men on the moon in 1969. The crew of this mission, including Neil Armstrong, Michael Collins, and Edwin "Buzz" Aldrin, were hailed as national heroes in the race to beat the USSR to the moon. The Apollo missions were a crucial cultural turning point in the Cold War and provided evidence of the great technological innovation and advancement that the US made as a result of the competitive pressure of their Soviet counterparts.

RELATED LITERARY WORKS

Ballard's work had a large impact on the literary world of the late-20th century. He is known to have admired Daniel Defoe's *Robinson Crusoe*, and he even coined the term "inverted Crusoeism" to describe characters who separate themselves from society on purpose, as opposed to Defoe's protagonist, who is accidentally marooned on an island. Scranton and the narrator in "The Man Who Walked on the Moon" are both inverted Crusoes. Charlotte Perkins Gilman's "The Yellow Wallpaper" similarly explores themes of isolation and its effect on perception. Like Ballard's story, Gilman's uses sight to explore the blurred lines between reality and fantasy. Both stories are also concerned with the ways in which powerful social structures oppress the powerless. Franz Kafka's *The Metamorphosis* is a third work vitally concerned with these topics: the novel's protagonist, Gregor Samsa, has a surreal experience that isolates him from his family and society. Another Ballard short story, "The Drowned Giant," explores the dissolution of identity over time and the ways in which the world around people shapes how they think of themselves.

KEY FACTS

- **Full Title:** The Man Who Walked on the Moon
- **Where Written:** Shepperton, England
- **When Published:** 1985 (*Interzone Magazine* Issue 13, Autumn 1985)
- **Literary Period:** New Wave Science Fiction
- **Genre:** Short Story, Science-Fiction, Psychological Fiction
- **Setting:** Copacabana Beach in Rio de Janeiro, Brazil
- **Climax:** Scranton dies, and the narrator replaces him as the phony ex-astronaut.
- **Antagonist:** Social expectations and structures of power
- **Point of View:** First Person

EXTRA CREDIT

Childhood Abroad. During the Second Sino-Japanese War, Ballard and his family were kept in an internment camp called the Lunghua Civil Assembly Center. They lived there for three years, and the experience became the basis for Ballard's *Empire of the Sun*.

Early Publication. "The Man Who Walked on the Moon" was originally published in *Interzone Magazine*, Issue 13. *Interzone*, then a fledgling publication, is now one of the longest running science-fiction magazines ever.



PLOT SUMMARY

"The Man Who Walked on the Moon" follows an unnamed narrator living in Rio de Janeiro, Brazil. The narrator is a middle-aged man who believes he was once an astronaut but cannot remember his training or space travels. He now spends his time sitting in a café and piecing together his past.

Earlier in life, the narrator is a failed journalist and translator who believes that his talent is unappreciated by his peers. Unable to continue paying to support his mother, he lets his mother move in with him and his wife. The two women pressure him to take writing jobs he loathes, and eventually, to his chagrin, he searches for a human-interest story. In a café, a pair of American tourists ask him if he is the astronaut known as Commander Scranton. They realize their mistake and instead approach a gaunt and tired man in the corner of the café; they buy him a drink and give him money while the narrator watches. The narrator remembers reading about a man who frequented rich hotels and was successful for a short time pretending to be an astronaut from the Apollo missions. When his lie was exposed, he took the charade to the poorer neighborhoods of Rio.

The narrator returns to the café for the next few days, hoping to write about Scranton and the fact that his exposure as a fraud hasn't stopped him. On the fourth day he approaches Scranton, pretending to be a film critic. Scranton's sincerity surprises him, and he realizes how isolated the man is. He accepts Scranton's invitation to see some photos of the moon landing that he supposedly took and now keeps in his apartment.

Scranton lives over the **Luxor Cinema** in a single, nasty room. He shows the narrator **photos** obviously cut from magazines. The narrator leaves, disappointed, but on his way home begins to see the world as Scranton does: it appears desolate, and he feels blissfully distant from the bustle of the city. At home, he tells his wife and mother that he's going to be working with Scranton.

The next time he sees Scranton, the man has fallen gravely ill. The narrator begins to take care of Scranton instead of working, acting as a sort of middleman between Scranton and the few tourists who still want their pictures taken with him. When the narrator's wife and mother eventually evict him, he moves into the room above the Luxor with Scranton. The more time they spend together, the more distant the narrator grows from the world. He experiences a strange form of **failing eyesight**, just like Scranton himself. When Scranton dies, the narrator barely notices. Later, the narrator discovers Scranton's pilot logs, proving that he was only ever a crop-duster, not an astronaut. He dismisses these logs and notes that he has begun to see himself and Scranton in the magazine photos of the moon landing. Finally, he replaces Scranton as the phony ex-

astronaut in the café where they met.



CHARACTERS

The Narrator – The unnamed narrator is a failed journalist living in Rio de Janeiro, Brazil. The narrator doesn't get along with his wife or his mother, though he lives with them both. Because he believes that his writing talent is unappreciated, he also dislikes his coworkers, and he feels isolated from and frustrated with everyone in his life. Simply put, he is alienated and jaded. When he meets Scranton, though, he identifies him as similarly isolated, feeling a strange kind of kinship with the man. The narrator tries to turn Scranton into a news story, hoping to make some money. Eventually, though, he becomes so invested in Scranton's lifestyle that he begins to integrate himself into Scranton's everyday life, and though he knows that Scranton is a phony astronaut, he starts to play into the fantasy that Scranton has actually visited the moon. As this intensifies, the narrator stops seeing people as anything more than mere shadows, illustrating just how little he feels for others. When his wife and mother evict him from their apartment and he quits his job, he ends up enjoying the process of cutting himself off from his loved ones. As he becomes more isolated, he convinces himself that he, too, was once an actual astronaut. Since he is so alone, nobody can hold him accountable to his past. When Scranton eventually dies, the narrator hardly cares. By the end of the story, the narrator replaces Scranton as the local phony astronaut, hardly seeing the world around him. To justify his fictional history as a real astronaut, he convinces himself that he has developed acute amnesia, and he totally changes his conception of the past to accommodate his own delusion.

Scranton – Prior to the story's events, Scranton was the subject of scandal around Copacabana Beach, as it was revealed that he was lying about being a famous astronaut. Despite the uncovering of his lies, he has continued to pose as an astronaut, charging tourists to take a picture with him—the only difference is that now he does this in a seedy café instead of in fancy hotels. The café is where he encounters the narrator. Scranton is a malnourished, ill, and mostly silent character onto whom the narrator projects his fantasies of solitude and freedom. From the beginning, Scranton represents what the narrator will inevitably become. He shows the narrator his home, hoping to be paid, and inadvertently demonstrates how to see the world with a distant and dehumanizing eye. From that point on, he falls so ill that he has no choice but to rely on the narrator. Scranton demonstrates the true toll of isolation, but the narrator remains unable or unwilling to see the ways in which Scranton has been negatively impacted by this delusional lifestyle. His poverty and detachment from reality has driven him to total reliance on a false narrative, and, as a result, he has lost—as the narrator eventually loses—any tether to the real

world.

The Narrator's Wife – The narrator's wife is a source of irritation for the narrator. She is disappointed with his career failures, and when his mother moves into their home, she resents the situation. The two women work together to try to convince the narrator to accept work that he deems beneath him. The narrator's desire for isolation is implicitly a desire to escape his wife and his mother, but his wife continues to support him, even after he leaves his job. In a last effort to reconcile, the narrator's wife persuades the narrator's newspaper editor to offer him a film review. When the narrator summarily and rudely declines the offer from the editor, he is effectively throwing away his final chance to make things work with his wife.

The Narrator's Mother – The narrator's mother moves in with the narrator and his wife when the narrator can no longer afford to pay for her to live elsewhere. Like his wife, the narrator's mother wants him to get serious about finding work as a journalist, and when he fails to do this, she bands together with his wife to kick him out of the apartment.



THEMES

In LitCharts literature guides, each theme gets its own color-coded icon. These icons make it easy to track where the themes occur most prominently throughout the work. If you don't have a color printer, you can still use the icons to track themes in black and white.



ISOLATION, DETACHMENT, AND REALITY

"The Man Who Walked on the Moon" explores the relationship between social isolation and

reality—or, more specifically, the ways in which isolation can impact a person's *perception* of reality. Although the narrator knows when he first meets Scranton that the man has never been to the moon, he finds Scranton's detachment from everyday life appealing. It's obvious to most people that Scranton is a fraud, but Scranton doesn't care, and it is this kind of passive self-assurance that most likely appeals to the narrator, who seems to crave an escape from the world around him and its many limitations and expectations. The narrator therefore adopts Scranton's lifestyle, and though doing so isolates him from his wife and mother while plunging him even deeper into poverty, he appears to welcome the detachment he experiences in this isolated life—perhaps because this detachment refigures the way he perceives his reality.

To put it another way, the narrator's isolation from everyday life allows him to detach from reality itself. In this sense, the story suggests that cutting oneself off from the various connections and expectations of society makes it easier to embrace

delusion. In the real world, the narrator is a struggling journalist who has failed to support himself and his loved ones. Isolating himself from society, however, enables the narrator to cultivate self-aggrandizing stories about himself as an astronaut. And by cultivating these stories, the narrator effectively severs any remaining ties with the surrounding world; after all, he is no longer living in a world bound to factuality or objectivity. Instead, he is in a world of his own making (or, perhaps, a world of Scranton's making)—one in which he isn't a failure. By tracking the narrator's willful descent into this kind of mental isolation, then, the story illustrates that detachment from daily life and its related rules and expectations can lead to an unmitigated kind of delusion.



MEMORY VS. HISTORY

"The Man Who Walked on the Moon" emphasizes the subjective nature of memory and the highly variable—and unreliable—way that people conceive

of the past. Although history itself might be set in stone, the way people process and reimagine past events ultimately depends on multiple factors, including their own motives for remembering things a certain way. For instance, the narrator of "The Man Who Walked on the Moon" takes advantage of the malleability of his own memory and uses it to reshape the way he thinks of himself: if he says he went to space, nobody can deny him that. Similarly, when Scranton claims that **photos** of the Apollo missions torn from popular magazines are his own pictures, he demonstrates an unwillingness to accept the real version of history, and it's quite difficult for anyone—the narrator included—to refute him, despite the fact that it's quite obvious that Scranton wasn't part of the Apollo missions. Seemingly inspired by Scranton's willfully incorrect memory of the past, the narrator eventually uses the flexibility of memory to serve his own means. In doing so, he shapes for himself a new identity that is preferable to that of a failed journalist, husband, and son. Under the guise of an "ex-astronaut," he can change his habits and reinforce a past that never existed. Memory is, in this sense, deeply subjective but also somewhat pragmatic, as the narrator uses it (or some deluded version of it) as a tool to justify an entirely new life. Like Scranton's memory, the narrator's memory effectively *becomes* his history. In turn, "The Man Who Walked on the Moon" highlights the tricky idea that the stories we tell ourselves about history are often just as important as what actually happened.



POVERTY, DISENFRANCHISEMENT, AND ESCAPISM

"The Man Who Walked on the Moon" illustrates just how far some people will go to gain a sense of escape from financial hardship and disenfranchisement. Both the narrator and Scranton reimagine themselves as astronauts, and—to a certain extent—this enables them to earn some

money, since gullible tourists will pay to have their pictures taken with an ex-astronaut. In this way, the two men slightly ease their poverty, but the escape they experience from this ruse also operates on a broader, more meaningful level. After all, their reimagination of their pasts distracts them from their otherwise dismal circumstances, providing them with an escape from the daily hardships that come along with their poverty.

What's more, the story subtly implies that Scranton and the narrator aren't the only people interested in escaping the drudgery of life in the working class, as evidenced by the cultural appetite for science-fiction movies about space travel, not to mention the fact that people will pay to talk to someone who left the world behind and went to the moon. In turn, it becomes clear that, though the narrator and Scranton overcommit to their fantasies, there are many people in the surrounding society who are also eager to briefly avoid the reality of their laboring lives. However, very little comes of such attempts to escape or transcend poverty and disenfranchisement. Indeed, Scranton and the narrator do little more than isolate themselves, and this only exacerbates their dire financial situations. With this in mind, the story acknowledges the impulse toward escapism while also highlighting just how difficult it is to overcome the monotony and financial challenges inherent to modern life.

enmeshed in his fantasies that he sees the Luxor's films as a threat to his constructed fantasies: when he is asked to review a movie there, he claims to know the film already and to "hope to see it banned from the city." The Luxor's symbolism, for the narrator, has inverted because he is so lost in fantasy that the cinema has actually come to function as a reminder of reality, which he cannot face. To review the movie there would mean acknowledging that his fantasy is a means of escape, rather than reality itself.



MOON LANDING PHOTOGRAPHS

Scranton's photographs of the Apollo 11 moon landing symbolize the growing distance between the characters and reality. When Scranton first shows the narrator the photos, the narrator is surprised at how obvious it is that the pictures were cut out of *Life* and *Newsweek*. He is moved, however, by how genuinely Scranton seems to believe that the photos include him. Both characters' connection to reality can be measured by how they see the pictures at any given time: at this point, the narrator is more aware of historical fact than Scranton is, so he sees the photos for what they are. As he grows to believe that he exists separate from the realistic Rio de Janeiro, though, he must reimagine history to change (what he believes to be) his present. His perception of the world grows hazier and less realistic, and he becomes convinced that he and Scranton *are* included in the photographs. Altering photographs is an action that is often intended to mislead others, but the narrator and Scranton only mislead themselves. As the photographs change in the narrator's mind, so does the narrator's idea about his past, suggesting that memory is malleable and doesn't always align with historical fact. Given that he sees himself in the photos but cannot remember going to the moon, the narrator has grounds to claim that he has "acute amnesia." This questionable self-diagnosis marks his final severance from the real world. The less realistic the narrator and Scranton are, the more clearly they seem to see themselves in the photos of the moon, and the photos thus come to represent the depths of the characters' delusion.



FAILING EYESIGHT

The narrator's failing eyesight symbolizes the ways in which he willfully embraces a certain kind of detachment from the surrounding world. It is especially notable that the narrator's blindness mostly manifests itself as an inability to see other people's faces. The narrator's inability (or refusal) to see faces demonstrates the possibly selective nature of his vision impairment—it's arguable, in fact, that his trouble seeing faces has more to do with his desire for social isolation than with any kind of physical disability. As he wills himself into failed eyesight, he changes the nature of his connection with



SYMBOLS

Symbols appear in **teal text** throughout the Summary and Analysis sections of this LitChart.



LUXOR CINEMA

The Luxor Cinema symbolizes the ways that people suffering in poverty and disenfranchisement rely on fantasy as an escape from their daily lives. The story is concerned with themes of poverty, and its characters "dream of escape." Without resources, the disenfranchised must rely on other methods of escapism than vacation and luxury: they turn, instead, to the Luxor Cinema and its fantastical narratives. The Luxor functions as the tamer counterpart to the narrator's and Scranton's extreme imaginations. While the two main characters literally refigure the world around them into a science-fiction landscape, their peers in poverty turn to the movies to cope with their struggles.

The Luxor also highlights a significant turning point in the narrator's decline, as his downfall is reflected in his relationship to the Cinema. At the beginning of the story, his relationship with the Luxor is one of an outsider: part of his journalism includes film reviews. As he loses touch with reality, though, he moves *inside* the Luxor, where science-fiction replaces reality all day, every day. By the end of the story, the narrator is so

other people. The narrator turns a literal blind eye to both his family and his job, and then he uses his failing eyesight and the subsequent isolation to justify his neglect. He feels detached with his new, limited eyesight, and he revels in this form of disconnection. By the time Scranton dies, the narrator finds him “barely visible,” perhaps because he has gotten so far from reality that he cannot even see the face of the person whose example he has followed. Similarly, even the city streets appear totally empty in his selective perception. In turn, the narrator’s blindness in “The Man Who Walked on the Moon” represents not just his *desire* for isolation but also the transformative power (for better or for worse) of *embracing* such a desire.

awareness. This, combined with his apparent memory (“for many years I believed this myself”), chafe against his claim of acute amnesia. Immediately, the story’s validity, as long as it comes from the narrator, is thrown into question. This instance also sets up the story’s use of contradiction, which will feature heavily as the narrator’s beliefs become more and more divorced from reality.

That the narrator denies having “no past and less future” emphasizes the story’s complicated relationship between memory and history. Puzzlingly, though, the narrator is about to tell a story about his past. And if this is the case, how can he be an amnesiac? Right away, the narrator effectively lies and then confesses to lying.



QUOTES

Note: all page numbers for the quotes below refer to the Cambridge University Press edition of *Stories of Ourselves: Volume 2* published in 2018.

The Man Who Walked on the Moon Quotes



[N]o doubt you think that I am a minor clerk who has missed promotion once too often, and that I amount to nothing, a person of no past and less future.

For many years I believed this myself. I had been abandoned by the authorities, who were glad to see me exiled to another continent, reduced to begging from American tourists. I suffered from acute amnesia, and certain domestic problems with my wife and my mother.

Related Characters: The Narrator (speaker), The Narrator’s Wife , The Narrator’s Mother

Related Themes:

Page Number: 328

Explanation and Analysis

This self-evaluation occurs in the narrator’s opening passage, as the narrator introduces himself and explains why he, an alleged former astronaut, looks as shabby and unfortunate as he does. The story here establishes the narrator’s relative unreliability, since it’s difficult to have confidence in an amnesiac narrator who is about to tell a story about something that happened in the past.

The narrator begins his story in the second-person point of view, likely addressing a character the reader never encounters (who is a stand-in for the reader themselves). This narrative perspective is significant, since it demonstrates that he retains a certain level of self-



My mother, whom I had supported for many years, was forced to leave her home and join my wife and myself in our apartment at Ipanema.

At first my wife resented this, but soon she and my mother teamed up against me. [...] [M]y journey to work was a transit between one door slammed on my heels and another slammed in my face.

Related Characters: The Narrator (speaker), The Narrator’s Wife , The Narrator’s Mother

Related Themes:

Page Number: 329

Explanation and Analysis

In this passage, the narrator recounts more relevant backstory, establishing his poverty as the reason for the undesirable conditions in which he lives. He struggles to see relationships as more than transactional, and his mother resembles, for him, only a financial hindrance. He treats her as an obstacle to be navigated, someone he must think of in terms of money rather than emotion. This is, implicitly, a result of his poverty: with more money, the narrator would both remain capable of financing his mother’s life and would have no occupational failure about which she and his wife could pressure him.

That the narrator’s wife at first “resents” the situation with his mother but then becomes allies with her suggests again that the story will operate in extremes: poverty, here, leaves no room for nuance. Relationships around the narrator either materialize or are severed instantaneously. The narrator, himself responsible for the family’s income, finds himself in an unfortunate position in seemingly all his

relationships. It is this reason that he so desires isolation and escape from his situation: when things go wrong, he is the one to blame.

☞ Around me were the million faces of the city. People strode past, so occupied with their own lives that they almost pushed me from the pavement. A million human interest stories of a banal and pointless kind, an encyclopaedia of mediocrity... Giving up, I left Copacabana Avenue and took refuge among the tables of a small café in a side-street.

It was there that I met the American astronaut, and began my own career in space.

Related Characters: The Narrator (speaker), Scranton

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 329

Explanation and Analysis

In this passage, the narrator is looking for a human interest story to revive his journalism career but feels totally detached from his community. He believes he has been wronged by the world at large, likely a result of his poverty, his unpopularity at work and at home, and his elitism. In his arrogance he refers to others as “an encyclopaedia of mediocrity,” and it becomes clear that the narrator’s isolation is ultimately something that he himself has facilitated. He believes himself better than his peers, his mother and wife, and the strangers he passes on the street, and he resents his situation among them. Lives that are not his are “banal and pointless,” despite the fact that he is out of work and doesn’t have much to keep him going. Again, the narrator is describing a world different to the one he truly occupies: his arrogant attitude demands he separate himself from others who are very like him. One of the narrator’s strategies of separation is to associate loneliness and merit: he seems to believe that special people, by virtue of their being special, must be alone, and then he claims his own specialness as an obvious reason for his isolation. It is a fallacious argument that supposes his own uniqueness.

Believing himself special, the narrator takes “refuge” in a café. The use of the word “refuge” only further demonstrates his belief that he does not belong among the allegedly mediocre. It suggests that he sees them as threatening his own merit and power.

☞ As I sat there, guarding the brandy I could barely afford, I resented Scranton’s bogus celebrity, and the tourist revenue it brought him. For years I, too, had maintained a charade — the mask of good humor that I presented to my colleagues in the newspaper world — but it had brought me nothing. Scranton at least was left alone for most of his time, something I craved more than any celebrity.

Related Characters: The Narrator (speaker), Scranton

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 331

Explanation and Analysis

The narrator, after recalling a news story about Scranton’s successful run as a fake astronaut among Rio de Janeiro’s elite, finds himself envious of both Scranton’s apparent income and his isolation. The narrator continues whining about feeling wronged, but he particularly loathes Scranton because of the similarities he and the man share: Scranton is the narrator’s foil, and any resentment harbored on the narrator’s part is likely a disguised self-loathing.

The narrator feels as though Scranton’s apparent income is undeserved; words like “bogus” and “charade” associate Scranton’s success with immorality or cheating, and thus conversely align the narrator’s failures with morality. As the story progresses, the convenient (and sometimes contradictory) beliefs that the narrator holds become clearer: they all situate him as the moral and intellectual center of his world. His condescension towards everyone else places him at the top of the proverbial food chain, but it is no stretch to say that the narrator is immediately envious of Scranton: Scranton had a smarter scheme than the narrator that made him, at least for a short period, a substantial income. What’s more, Scranton’s situation is an example for the narrator of how one might indulge a certain kind of isolation by delving deeply into a fantasy world that ultimately disregards—and even exploits—the customs of the surrounding society.

☞ Yet there was a certain resolute quality about this vagrant figure that I had not expected. Sitting beside him, I was aware of an intense and almost wilful isolation, not just in this foreign city, but in the world at large.

Related Characters: The Narrator (speaker), Scranton

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 332

Explanation and Analysis

In this passage, the narrator has approached Scranton and noticed the true extent of his isolation. What at first appeared to be Scranton's exhaustion and malnourishment now seems, to the narrator, like an existential distance from the world that has separated Scranton so wholly that he cannot be affected by outside forces. And this, it seems, appeals to the narrator. In light of this, the narrator's use of the word "vagrant" becomes less demeaning—after all, the vagrant is socially positioned away from others, just as the astronaut is physically positioned beyond the reaches of society. In both cases, distance from others is something the narrator envies, as he would like to be so removed that he can't be held accountable for his actions. Regardless of whether or not Scranton's stories are true, he has certainly achieved this social outsider position. This means that, unlike the narrator, he has complete control over his life and does not recognize the social and familial expectations that the narrator feels trap him in his own life. That Scranton apparently achieved this position "wilful[ly]" tempts the narrator further. If Scranton can position himself outside society on purpose, then perhaps the narrator can, too.

☞ Scranton embodied the absolute loneliness of the human being in space and time, a situation which in many ways I shared. Even the act of convincing himself that he was a former astronaut only emphasized his isolation.

Related Characters: The Narrator (speaker), Scranton

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 333

Explanation and Analysis

In this passage, the narrator has started a conversation with Scranton about the accuracy of science-fiction films. It is this point at which the narrator dehumanizes Scranton the same way he has his wife and mother. By saying that Scranton "embodies" loneliness, the narrator makes him a symbol for an idea rather than treating him like a person. Scranton never escapes his symbolic status.

Scranton's loneliness is then framed in "space and time." Again, the narrator conflates social isolation with the astronaut's isolation: only an astronaut could exist outside measurable space and time. The narrator's poverty makes

him feel as though he, too, belongs to no space or time, but his experience of Scranton is one truly founded on envy or aspiration.

The passage also serves as foreshadowing. Now that the narrator has relegated Scranton to a symbol rather than character, Scranton becomes doubly meaningful: he foreshadows what will happen to the narrator if he pursues his current line of thinking. This foreshadowing begins right away: the narrator says that Scranton is "convincing himself" of his past as an astronaut. The narrator clearly disbelieves that Scranton was ever a real astronaut and instead thinks the man is doing whatever he can to convince himself of the past. This is reminiscent of the convenient amnesia the narrator claims at the beginning of the story: though he hasn't reached that point chronologically, readers know that Scranton's "convincing himself" will soon be replicated by the narrator, as the confusion between memory and history becomes even murkier.

☞ Seeing the passers-by through his eyes, I was aware that they had begun to seem almost transparent, shadow players created by a frolic of the sun.

Related Characters: The Narrator (speaker), Scranton

Related Themes:  

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 333

Explanation and Analysis

In this passage, the narrator is walking with Scranton back to his quarters, and he starts to experience a new perspective that he believes he shares with Scranton. It is significant that, without evidence, the narrator states confidently that Scranton also sees with this failing eyesight. This is the culmination of the narrator's building speculation about what Scranton sees: first he thinks the man's gaze is simply tired, and then he starts to imagine how Scranton sees the world. Eventually, like his amnesia, he seems to force himself to see that which he imagines Scranton sees, though it can only be an act of his own imagination.

Again, the narrator decides, without validation, to interpret the world in a self-serving way. He knows next to nothing about Scranton and can only say with certainty that the man has separated himself out of society. As the narrator wants to do this because he dislikes people, he assumes that

Scranton acted from the same motivation: he sees people as dehumanizingly “transparent,” conveniently associating their faces with space imagery as “shadow players created by a frolic of the sun.” The narrator is using what little he knows about Scranton to create another form of isolation that allows him to ignore and discount his fellow humans.

☞ I peered at Scranton, expecting some small show of embarrassment. These faded pages, far from being the mementoes of a real astronaut, were obviously the prompt cards of an impostor. However, there was not the slightest doubt that Scranton was sincere.

Related Characters: The Narrator (speaker), Scranton

Related Themes:  

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 334

Explanation and Analysis

In this passage, Scranton shows the narrator the moon photos he has been keeping in his apartment, and the narrator is disappointed by how obvious it is that Scranton cut the pages out of magazines. It marks the first time in the story that the narrator’s conveniently constructed worldview is challenged. Scranton is not a success story waiting to be popularized. The narrator reverts to using language associated with insincerity to describe Scranton, likening the photos to an actor’s “prompt cards” and outright calling Scranton an “impostor.”

Quickly, however, his tune changes, and he returns to the sort of cognitive dissonance that marks his character. When he interprets Scranton as sincere, he accepts the fact that Scranton believes in his constructed history. Inventing and investing in a false history is a dangerous model to follow, but the narrator has committed to mimicking Scranton. Scranton’s sincerity acts as a sort of permission for the narrator to invent a false past for himself, and the deliberate confusion between memory and factual history will only serve the narrator as he continues to deliberately misinterpret reality. The story thus associates sincerity with its opposite—deception. Playing these ideas off one another creates a gray area in which the truth becomes whatever a character believes; it is this area the narrator constructs, maintains, and abuses.

☞ [A] small distance had opened between myself and the congested world. My meeting with Scranton, my brief involvement with this marooned man, allowed me to see everything in a more detached way. The businessmen with their briefcases, the afternoon tarts swinging their shiny handbags, the salesmen with their sheets of lottery tickets, almost deferred to me. Time and space had altered their perspectives, and the city was yielding to me.

Related Characters: The Narrator (speaker), Scranton

Related Themes:  

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 335

Explanation and Analysis

The next period of the story is bookended by the narrator’s failing eyesight, and this passage, when he is leaving Scranton’s home for the first time, begins his descent into a fantastical interpretation of the world that, conveniently, allows him to ignore his responsibilities. Again, the narrator enters a sort of trance that seems accessible to him alone, giving readers reason to doubt its legitimacy. It is notable that the people the narrator feels “detached” from are no different from those he would normally feel distant from: all three examples he provides demonstrate some sort of wealth: the businessman has his briefcase, the women their fancy purses, and the salesmen their lottery tickets. Interestingly, the narrator does *not* note his distance from other disenfranchised people. Instead, he only continues to feel different from the rich or, at least, from financially stable middle-class citizens, which suggests that the “distance between [him]self and the congested world” is a convenient way for the narrator to ignore his responsibilities.

☞ Nonetheless, Scranton had travelled in space. He had known the loneliness of separation from all other human beings, he had gazed at the empty perspectives that I myself had seen. Curiously, the pages torn from the news magazines seemed more real than the pilot’s log-book. The photographs of Armstrong and his fellow astronauts were really of Scranton and myself as we walked together on the moon of this world.

Related Characters: The Narrator (speaker), Scranton

Related Themes:  

Related Symbols:  

Page Number: 337

Explanation and Analysis

In this passage the narrator cements his withdrawal from reality, as he finds the late Scranton's old pilot-log books, acknowledges that they prove that Scranton never went to space, and decides not to pay attention to them or let them direct him back to reality. The narrator's conflation between social isolation and space is complete: he claims that the reality he lives in might as well be space itself. His life, as he has recounted it, has been a series of irresponsible

decisions and delusions that have allowed him to recede from his family and job without guilt: *this*, to him, is space.

When he admits to seeing himself and Scranton in the moon photographs, he all but confesses to having created a false past to justify a false present; when he uses the word "curiously" to describe that process, he once again absolves himself from guilt. "Curiously" implies a certain amount of ignorance about how the pictures changed. Readers, however, know that the narrator himself merely imagined this change, but his use of the word "curiously" suggests that he has not yet accepted his role in the creation of this surreal dimension



SUMMARY AND ANALYSIS

The color-coded icons under each analysis entry make it easy to track where the themes occur most prominently throughout the work. Each icon corresponds to one of the themes explained in the Themes section of this LitChart.

THE MAN WHO WALKED ON THE MOON

The narrator, sitting in a café near Rio de Janeiro's Copacabana Beach, claims to have been an astronaut, despite his tattered clothes and accessories. He knows that he looks like a failure and says, "no doubt you think that I am [...] a person of no past and less future," and he confesses to have believed this about himself once. Now, with acute amnesia and having been kicked out of an apartment he used to share with his wife and mother, he is regaining confidence and feels certain that, though he cannot remember his training or trips to space, he was once an astronaut.

The narrator recalls his past as an unsuccessful journalist whose shortcomings isolated him from his peers. The effect on his income means he can no longer afford to pay for his mother to live on her own, and she moves into the apartment he shares with his wife. They team up against him, pressuring him to find writing jobs. On the advice of an acquaintance, he turns to the streets for a human-interest story and, in this way, finds an American astronaut alone in a café. He watches as the astronaut, a man with a distant gaze named Scranton, is approached by a tourist couple. They buy Scranton a drink and pay to have their pictures taken with him.

When a waiter suggests that the man is not actually an astronaut, the narrator remembers a news story from two years prior. An American, posing as an astronaut, was kicked out of the Copacabana Beach hotels when his ruse was exposed. He moved his act to the cafés, where he made money sharing fake stories memorized from news reports of the Apollo missions. The narrator recognizes Scranton as this same phony astronaut, but he resents that Scranton earned both income and solitude from being caught in his lie. Seeing an opportunity for a human-interest story that might revive his career, he begins to frequent the café, observing Scranton's habits.

From the quote about his past and future and his claim of amnesia, readers may mark the narrator as unreliable. The stark difference between his appearance and his alleged profession only make him more questionable as a narrative authority, and his lonesome status suggests that he has nobody to hold him accountable. Already, the narrator is constructing reality in a convenient way for himself: his amnesia and loneliness mean that he can tell his story however he wants, and nobody can demand from him a perfectly true version of events.



While the narrator believes his talents are underappreciated, his lack of stable income means that his hand is often forced when it comes to making decisions. This leads to his general unhappiness, but it also demonstrates one of the story's most important themes: poverty and its effect on the disenfranchised. The narrator's situation suggests that agency, or the ability to freely make one's own decisions, is often significantly impacted by income (or a lack thereof). This is reinforced when the narrator first meets Scranton, who appears to be making money while living on his own, a situation the narrator finds enviable. The narrator conflates Scranton's monetary success with his own desire for freedom.



As the narrator remembers the news article about Scranton, the story's history becomes conflated with the narrator's memory. This relationship proves confusing for readers already mistrusting the narrator who, in the present, claims to be suffering from amnesia. It is at this point that the lines between memory and history begin to blur, and the narrator's memory, regardless of whether it can be trusted, serves as the only source readers have to access and evaluate the past. This means that the narrator, who readers know is not trustworthy, is in total control of the context through which the rest of Scranton's story is told.



The narrator, enamored with Scranton's gaze at "an invisible space [...] an imaginary moon," comes to realize that the phony astronaut's situation is not as lucrative as he first believed. When the staff at the café attempt to remove Scranton, the narrator steps in, posing as a film critic looking for a source to evaluate the portrayal of space in science-fiction films. Up close, he understands how malnourished and ill Scranton is, but he still cannot help his jealousy of Scranton's isolation. He comes to believe that Scranton represents "the absolute loneliness of the human being in space and time."

There's a certain instability to this scene, since readers can recognize that none of what either the narrator or Scranton claims is true. Scranton is a phony astronaut, and the narrator is pretending to be a film critic. However, while Scranton's lie is a scripted performance, the narrator is using his own lie to examine Scranton closely. And this, in turn, suggests that the narrator is perhaps drawn to Scranton in a meaningful way—he isn't just interested in Scranton because he wants to write a human-interest piece. Rather, he's interested in Scranton because the man has achieved "absolute loneliness," and it becomes increasingly clear that this is the kind of isolation to which the narrator aspires.



Fascinated, the narrator accepts Scranton's invitation back to his lodging to see **photos of the moon**—alleged proof of his trip. In trying to understand how Scranton has achieved his isolation, the narrator attempts to see the world through Scranton's eyes. When he does, his **eyesight fails**, and he begins to see passers-by as faceless and translucent. At Scranton's home, a revolting room above a science-fiction **cinema**, Scranton retrieves photos of the Apollo missions from *Time* and *Newsweek*—photos that are obviously not his own. The narrator, having slowly come to hope that Scranton was, in fact, involved in the Apollo missions, is disappointed. Still, he notes that, although he is an obvious fraud, Scranton is totally sincere in his belief about his own space adventures.

The narrator becomes so compelled by his understanding of Scranton's situation that he seems to will his own eyesight to fail, believing (without confirmation) that Scranton's own eyes must be similarly weak. The first thing he fails to see are people's faces, suggesting that his partial blindness might be an affected attempt at isolation rather than a real physical condition. The narrator begins to see the world differently, as a place where people are less real. Scranton's photos then foreshadow the narrator's future: like the phony astronaut, he, too, will come to have a shaky relationship with both his memory and history. At this point, readers might be reminded of the narrator's amnesia. In keeping with this, Scranton also seems to have a complicated relationship with history. Both men (allegedly) have a loose grasp on their pasts, which allows them to believe whatever falsities best support their present desires.



The encounter with Scranton leaves the narrator feeling euphorically detached from the world, and as he walks home, he finds himself unbothered by many of the irritating aspects of the city. He feels divinely separate, claiming that "[t]ime and space had altered their perspectives, and the city was yielding to [him]." At home, his new demeanor leads his wife and mother to believe he found writing success, but he informs them that he is switching careers to join Scranton in the café. Chasing the feeling that the astronaut inspired in him, the narrator returns to the café every day, and he eventually steps in to assist the astronaut when it becomes apparent that Scranton is too ill and weak to continue.

The narrator has discovered a form of escapism: he can simply deny reality in favor of fantasy. He practices this on his walk home, truly believing that the state of Rio de Janeiro has changed relative to him. He experiences more than a change in perspective: it is as though he considers himself removed from the fabric of the city. Having manipulated his own relationship with both his poverty and his routine, he feels a liberation that he does not necessarily have. Regardless, the feeling of that liberation motivates him to change his career, but joining Scranton at the café only means that—to continue to feel his euphoria—the narrator must also consistently maintain his believed detachment from reality.



The narrator walks Scranton home, and it takes nearly half an hour to travel a quarter mile. For the narrator, though, this is time spent in a happy daze, as he revels in being with the distant astronaut and feeling like time has become “an elastic dimension.” The narrator spends every day with Scranton, and he begins to experience the same total distance from humanity and murky vision that he believes Scranton shares. He sees people as faceless “tricks of the sun” and comes to know what Scranton truly meant when he claimed to have been to space.

The narrator's isolation expands, and so does his self-constructed reality. He spends more time with Scranton, but because of the man's condition, it is effectively time spent alone; even when Scranton plays an active role, it only serves to validate the narrator's recession from reality. It is because of his newfound failure to see faces and accurately perceive the passage of time that the narrator first feels he has explored outer space. He understands space not as a physical place outside the world but a state of being separate from people, past the point of reconciliation.



In a final effort to get him back on track, the narrator's wife convinces the newspaper editor to offer him a film review. The narrator rejects the opportunity, saying that he would rather see this film banned from the city. He then leaves the job and is evicted by his wife and mother. He moves into Scranton's single room, where he finds that Scranton's health requires constant attention. Spending so much time with an infirm Scranton, the narrator recedes further into his desired isolation, where the world seems empty of people and details. Even as Scranton dies, the narrator hardly notices him. As the only attendee of Scranton's funeral, the narrator reflects that he and the phony astronaut are “the only real inhabitants of the city.”

By rejecting his editor's offer, the narrator severs his last ties to both his wife and to society: it is significant that the offer was to cover a science-fiction movie and that the narrator claims to know the film too well already. His refusal to engage with science fiction suggests that he knows how fragile his isolation and fantasies are; to acknowledge that the science-fiction film is fictional would be to similarly acknowledge his own fantasies as false. To cope, he turns to Scranton, a man so ill that he cannot provide any reminder of reality. The narrator leverages Scranton's loose grasp on reality to, again, validate his own fantasies. By the time of Scranton's death, Scranton has become more of an idea to a narrator than a companion. He leaves no legacy in the world that does not now belong to the narrator, who adjusts his conception of both Scranton and the narrator himself—in his delusion—as real astronauts.



The narrator finds, among Scranton's things, pilot logs suggesting he was a crop duster in Florida during the Apollo missions. Despite the proof that Scranton was never an astronaut, the narrator continues to validate Scranton's experience, as Scranton had “known the loneliness of separation from all other human beings.” He begins to see himself and Scranton in the magazine photos of real astronauts, and he finally takes Scranton's place as the tourists' astronaut, waiting in the cafe. From his chair, having inherited Scranton's isolating gaze, he looks out on a Rio de Janeiro that looks like a desolate planetary landscape with “empty vistas devoid of human beings.”

The narrator finally and definitively dismisses reality after discovering the pilot logs. Since the evidence that Scranton was a crop duster does not coincide with the new reality the narrator has constructed (nor with the past he has imagined, which is necessary for the maintenance of his new reality), he simply ignores the proof that Scranton was never an astronaut. His reality is delicately balanced, and he refers again to his belief that space and the experiences of an astronaut are more about isolation than physical exploration. Totally dissociated from the world and having lost his last companion, he is free to interpret his reality as it suits him, and he adjusts his eyesight so that he sees himself and Scranton in the photographs of the moon landing. To make sense of this fact, he indulges what is seemingly another delusion by claiming that he suffers from acute amnesia. Thus, both past and present fall completely under his control, as long as he stays isolated enough to avoid accountability. To ensure this, he reimagines the city itself as a lonely planet, justifying each of his fantasies so far in a final, massive swoop. He has not escaped his otherwise unrewarding life, but he believes that he has..





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